or other European peasants and workmen...great caution must be exercised in the struggle against religious prejudice.'[123] Lessons also appear to have been learnt about Asian nationalism from the early Bolshevik encounters in Central Asia. In March 1918, the first Bolshevik attempt at deposing the Bokharan emir had failed, largely because Alim had been able to gather widespread support from his subjects in the face of what was a blatant foreign invasion.[124] When Russia tried again in 1920, it was careful to first orchestrate a 'spontaneous' uprising by the Young Bukharans before sending in troops to aid them.[125] This subtle manipulation of nationalist feeling to ultimately achieve revolutionary ends is indicative of how far the Bolsheviks had progressed from their early confusion and heavy-handedness in Asia.

Fortunately for Lenin and his colleagues, 1920 was a year of particular Muslim unrest, largely as a result of the Caliphate affair. If the loss of Enzeli was the biggest military blunder of the British government in 1920, its handling of the Caliphate issue was arguably the greatest diplomatic mistake of the post-war period.[126] The problem centred on the fact that the Sultan of Turkey was also the Caliph, the ostensible head of Islam. Thus, when Allied forces took control of Constantinople in October 1918 following the armistice of Mudros, there was immediate fear throughout the Muslim world that the Caliph would have his power and status significantly curbed. The defeat of Turkey – the last truly independent Islamic power – was difficult enough for Muslims to have to stomach, without seeing their spiritual leader degraded too. In India, as pan-Islamic feeling had grown, so too had sympathy with the Caliph in Istanbul. After the Indian Mutiny and the deposition of the last Moghul emperor, Indian Muslims needed a symbol of Muslim solidarity and the Caliph appeared to be it.[127]

Hence, in the aftermath of the First World War, the Caliphate issue had the potential to create mass discontent among Indian Muslims, a fact that was recognised by the India Office: on 5 January 1920, at a conference of ministers, Montagu argued that harsh treatment of Turkey would have a great and negative effect on India. It was pointed out that nearly all Indian (and Mesopotamian) experts agreed that if the Allies removed the Sultan/Caliph from Constantinople, there would be dangerous consequences. For Curzon, however, the only way to assure Britain's